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[00:11:31] House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Head page. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled to privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery. The members will rise and be led in prayer by the Honorable Luke E. Torian, the Delegate from Prince William, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Heron. Let us pray. For the state that you've given to us, dear God, we are grateful unto you. For the bounty of your blessings that

[00:12:09] you share with us, we give you thanks. We give you glory and we give you honor. We're here because of the great mercy that you extend to each of us. And as we gather on this day to do the business for the Commonwealth of Virginia, we ask your blessings upon each of these legislators. We thank you for the sacrifices that their family makes so that they can come here and represent 8.8 million Virginians. And on this very special day when we recognize and celebrate the life of the Reverend dr martin luther king jr may we all govern ourselves with the convictions that he shared

[00:12:48] with us that we care for others before we care for ourselves we thank you for our leadership and we ask your blessings upon our time together today in your holy name i pray amen

[00:13:00] the clerk will report the results of the special elections that occurred on the 77th 11th and 23rd

[00:13:39] House of Delegates District. Members, please be advised, pursuant to Article 4, Section 7 of the Virginia Constitution, providing that the House of Delegates, quote, shall judge of the election qualification and returns of its members, unquote, I am pleased to report the following. In the special election called by the Speaker to fill the vacancy in the 77th House District, House of Delegates District, which occurred on Tuesday, January 6th, it has been determined that Charlie H. Schmidt received a majority of the votes cast and was duly sworn into office earlier today.

[00:14:10] In the special election call by the Speaker to fill the vacancy in the 11th House of Delegates District, which occurred on Tuesday, January 13, 2026, it has been determined that Gretchen M. Bulova received a majority of the votes cast and also was duly sworn into office earlier today.

[00:14:26] And finally, in the special election call by the Speaker to fill the vacancy in the 23rd House of Delegates District, which occurred on Tuesday, January 13, 2026. It has been determined that Margaret Angela Franklin received a majority of the votes cast and was duly sworn into office earlier today. Congratulations. Congratulations. Now you have to do some work. The members will

[00:15:03] answer the roll call by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board. Clerk will close the roll. Mr. Speaker, a quorum is present. Pursuant to House Rule 3, I would examine and approve the Journal of the House of Delegates for Saturday, January 17, 2026.

[00:15:29] Motions and resolutions under Rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Does the clerk have any announcements or communication? Yes, sir, Mr. Speaker. Communication from the speaker to the clerk. I've made the following committee assignments effective today. Delegate Bulova appointed the Committee on Privileges and Elections, Committee on Education, and the Committee on Finance.

[00:15:50] Delegate Franklin, Margaret. Delegate Franklin is appointed to the Committee on Finance. and the Committee on County, Cities, and Towns. Delegate Schmidt is appointed to the Committee for Courts of Justice and the Committee on Communications, Technology, and Innovation.

[00:16:07] In addition, the Speaker is making a change, removing Delegate Dougherty from the Committee on County, Cities, and Towns, and Delegate Keyes-Gamara is going on to see CNT. Mr. Speaker, that's all the announcements I have.

[00:16:23] So therefore, in this first portion of the morning hour, Our speaker request to use your request to speak button for the agenda items listed for reference up on the voting board. Delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourns in the honor of former Delegate and Circuit Court Judge Ford C. Quillen.

[00:16:44] I would like to speak to that motion. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, ladies and gentlemen of the House, deep respect and sadness that I rise today to honor the life and legacy of Ford Quillen, passed away yesterday. Ford C. Quillen was one of the most consequential public servants in the House and he was a proud son of Southwest Virginia who devoted his life to the people he represented and to the Commonwealth he loved. For more than two decades he served in this chamber with distinction representing the very district that I'm honored to serve today. He was a delegate before me and I'm mindful every day that I stand in the foundation he built for our

[00:17:22] region and for this institution. He earned a reputation as a thoughtful leader, a skilled legislator, and a tireless advocate for rural Virginia. Among his lasting contributions, he carried legislation that created the Virginia Cofield Economic Development Authority, Route 58 funding, and he laid the groundwork for economic opportunity and revitalization in southwest Virginia. He was a strong champion for education, Mr. Speaker, and his leadership and support were instrumental in strengthening Mountain Empire Community College in helping to expand access to workforce training in our area.

[00:17:58] Beyond the Capitol, his leadership continued and he strengthened higher education with his service at UVA Wise. Mr. Speaker, those of us who serve from Southwest Virginia walk in the path that he helped pave.

[00:18:14] His wisdom, his steady counsel, and his dedication to public service will long be remembered. Our condolences go out to his daughters, Madre, Carter, and Lenore, and Mr. Speaker, on behalf of the members from Southwest Virginia, and to honor this extraordinary service to the Commonwealth, I ask that this house adjourn today in the memory and honor of Ford C. Quillen.

[00:18:36] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore, moves that when the house adjourns today, do so in the honor and memory of the Honorable Fred C. Quillen. All those in favor, Ford C. Quillen, all those in favor shall rise. Motion is agreed to.

[00:18:57] The delegate from Arlington, Delegate Hope. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for introduction. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, members of the body, I rise today to welcome Rise for Youth and their Youth Leader Advocacy Network to the gallery. And I'd ask them to please stand to be recognized.

[00:19:14] Rise is dedicated to replacing punitive models with restorative community-based solutions that empower Virginia's young people. At the heart of their mission is the Youth Leader Advocacy Network, a collective of young leaders who transform their lived experiences into statewide policy change through advocacy and leadership training.

[00:19:33] The organization has been a vital partner in legislative work of this body. They've been very effective. House Bill 1912, the bill that I was fortunate to sponsor, legislation that ended the collection of child support for families of incarcerated youth. House Bill 266 in 2024 by Delegate Watts, I looked for her over here, she's moved on me, ensuring that youth rights are protected during custodial interrogations.

[00:19:59] And last year, Delegate Glass, House Bill 2692, introduced prohibiting the use of deception by law enforcement when questioning minors. RISE supports our Commonwealth's future through their Youth Development Academy, setting our youth on a path toward career growth and long-term success.

[00:20:16] They're building a future where every young Virginia is met with dignity, support, and opportunity. Please join me in the House to give a warm House welcome to Rise for Youth and their talented young youth leaders.

[00:20:39] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Cohen. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate, that's the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, joining us in the gallery today is the Fairfax County Federation of Teachers.

[00:20:56] If they wouldn't mind rising. FCFT represents educators and workers who show up every day for our students, families, and staff. FCFT is a strong, collaborative voice for public education, workers' rights and dignity, and student success in our schools.

[00:21:15] We appreciate their commitment to our entire community, and I hope my colleagues will join me in giving the members of FCFT a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:21:39] The Delegate from Montgomery County, Delegate Franklin. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. And today in the gallery, we have medical students from the Edward Vaya College of Osteopathic Medicine who traveled from Blacksburg to visit the Capitol.

[00:21:58] I would ask them to rise to be recognized. VCOM's mission is to educate community-focused physicians who are committed to caring for rural and medically underserved communities across the southeast, including the region surrounding their campus in southwest Virginia.

[00:22:13] This year, VCOM will graduate its 20th class of physicians, and its alumni are approving access to care and health care outcomes all across the Commonwealth. VCOM is also an active advocate for thoughtful public health policy and the future of medicine in Virginia.

[00:22:29] These students came to speak with many of us as representatives of the Medical Society of Virginia, advocating for issues related to the practice of medicine, including student loan repayment, medical downcoding, non-compete clauses, and workplace violence.

[00:22:45] I would like to wish them the best of luck in their course of studies and ask the body to give them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:23:04] The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Cousins. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction and a motion. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, in the gallery today we have friends and family of Adam Turk, and I would ask that they please rise.

[00:23:23] Adam Turk was a beloved actor, personal trainer, and community advocate who lived in the Shaco Bottom neighborhood of the city of Richmond. Adam loved all things related to comic book heroes, but had a special affinity for Superman, even having the iconic Superman S tattooed on his shoulder.

[00:23:44] He could always be counted on to help a person in need. Last August, Adam was tragically shot and killed while attempting to help a neighbor in need. His actions saved his neighbor's life, even as he lost his own. Adam's friends and family are gathered here today to advocate for gun violence reform in his memory.

[00:24:05] I request that the members join me in extending a warm House welcome.

[00:24:22] And, Mr. Speaker, I move that when we adjourn today, we do so in the honor and memory of Adam Turk. The delegate from Richmond City moves that when the House adjourns today, it do so in the honor and memory of Adam Turk. All those in favor shall please rise. The motion is agreed to.

[00:24:45] Pursuing to House Rule 30, the journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business on a granted leave from today's session, Delegates Knight and Sebald. Clerk will announce the next article. Mr. Speaker, the second portion of the morning hour, a member request to move legislation is not applicable given today's calendar.

[00:25:06] Clerk will announce the next article. Third portion of the morning hour, a member request for legislation to go by for the day. If any, in the subsequent motion by the Majority Leader, I am not aware of any such requests. Clerk will announce the next. and the fourth and final portion of the morning hour is reserved for member requests for points of personal privilege privilege and the speaker kindly requests

you use your request to speak button the delegate from spotsylvania delegate scott thank you mr speaker i rise for a point of personal privilege delegate on the floor thank you mr speaker mr speaker today i would like to speak to the sanctity of human life day which was observed yesterday uh sanctity human life is

[00:25:40] important to all of us we should hold dear that all life born and unborn are valuable mr speaker I have spoken on this house floor, and even in years past, my daughter, Brianna, has been here in this chamber to speak to the importance that every person has value, every person has purpose.

[00:26:02] We were told by the specialists, the experts, that she wasn't going to live, that the pregnancy was not viable. See, my wife and I, we recognize that life is not something you choose to accept or choose to terminate. Life is an obligation that parents have to support, to care for when it comes to their children. We would do that for any of our children, no matter their age.

[00:26:29] And so their gestational age doesn't matter either. And so Brianna, diagnosed with trisomy 18, had holes in her heart, had digestive issues, and we were told that her progression of life was coming to an end. We did not think that there was an option to choose life. We knew that there was an obligation that we had as parents to give her the support that she needed and so we delivered her early via c-section thinking that we were going to have family in town to celebrate her birth and mourn her passing. Mr. Speaker I hope to have her here this year. She is six and a half years

[00:27:05] old. She has been given the support that she needs and trisomy 18 because parents recognition that life is not something to choose or not choose but to respect and support and honor trisomy 18 is no longer considered not compatible with life. And so parents who recognize the sanctity of human life, no matter the diagnosis of their child, have moved the needle in the medical community. They have helped medical innovation advance to provide the support that these children need. My daughter had

[00:27:39] heart surgery after just a few months of age. She had surgery on her digestive system after just a few days of life, all have given her a life worth living. She was the Children's Miracle Network Champion for Children's National Hospital in 2021 and helped raise millions of dollars for children treated at that hospital. There was a specific fundraiser event that we participated in where they were trying to raise money for a travel event. Not only did Brianna help raise money for that

[00:28:12] travel vent she also raised above and beyond and so the hospital was able to buy refrigerator freezer combos for each room in the NICU to allow mothers to store breast milk and freeze breast milk there in the hospital rooms so Mr. Speaker today as we recognize the sanctity of human life that all life is valuable all are created in the image of God and every pre-born child has those same rights to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness, I encourage everybody in this chamber to take a moment and think of how they can encourage a pregnant mother in that journey of

[00:28:51] bringing a new life into this world. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Henrico County, Delegate McQuinn. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise to our point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker and colleagues,

[00:29:18] Today, the Virginia Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial Commission, which I am proud to serve as chair of, joined the nation in celebrating the life of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. The King Commission was created by the General Assembly in 1992 to honor the memory and the legacy of Dr. King and for more than 30 years have strived to continue his work.

[00:29:42] Continuing the work of Dr. King has always been an enormous and daunting task. In his short lifetime, Dr. King shaped the conscience of this nation. He constantly and tirelessly sacrifices time and energy in pursuit of a vision of a beloved community in which peace and justice and love prevail over hatred and division.

[00:30:06] He risked his own comfort and safety and ultimately lost his own life in the pursuit of a better world. now more than a century after his death, we still strive to achieve his dream and live by his example. However, events of the past year have left us with a sharper awareness of the work that remains to be done to achieve Dr. King's beloved community. Dr. King would certainly recognize our present moment immediately. He often said that problems of racism and economic exploitation

[00:30:46] and militarism are all tied together, and he would see the treatment of immigrants and others as a part of that same moral crisis he confronted in his own time. Dr. King's message to the Republicans, to Democrats, to Independents, Black, White, and all races of people would be that it is not about—he would not focus on party label, but moral accountability.

[00:31:14] He will remind all of us that are in leadership that power divorced from compassion becomes tyranny, and that laws lacking justice ultimately undermines democracy itself. He will likely say to all of us that what many think that the immigrants particularly are not a threat to the nation's soul, how they are treated is.

[00:31:40] That fear-based politics and racialized language and punitive policies echo the same logic once used to justify segregation, exclusion, and violence against other marginalized people in this country.

[00:31:57] That a nation claiming to be guided by Christian values cannot ignore Jesus' command to welcome the stranger while criminalize human desperation. Dr. King believed that injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere.

[00:32:15] He would insist that the dehumanization of people through mass detention, family separation, demonizing rhetoric, and the denial of due process is not a border issue, but a moral issue. He would challenge leaders to ask not, is this popular or is this politically advantageous?

[00:32:38] But he would ask the question, is this just? The beloved community, and it's the urgency of it, is now. Dr. King's vision of the beloved community was never sentimental or naive. It was a radical reordering of society, grounded in justice, shared humanity, and mutual responsibility.

[00:33:01] In today's political climate, marked by division, misinformation, and sometimes lies, and deliberate mischaracterization of black people, brown, immigrants, and poor communities, his vision is more urgent than ever.

[00:33:19] The beloved community matters now because communities are being reduced to stereotypes rather than seen as families and workers and contributors. Fear is being weaponized to divide people who share common struggles and economic insecurity, lack of healthcare and underfunded schools.

[00:33:38] Language is being used to erase dignity, just as it was used in King's era to justify Jim Crow and racial terror. Dr. King warned that the greatest stumbling block, and he said in his words, is not the KKK, but those who prefer order to justice.

[00:34:00] Today, he would extend that warning to political leaders who prioritize, and they are of all races, all walk of life, but they prioritize border optics over human life and political gain over moral truth.

[00:34:16] Why this dream still speaks to us at this moment is because Dr. King's dream endures because it demands that America live up to its own professed idea. The beloved community insists that no group's humanity is negotiable.

[00:34:33] Justice must be consistent and not selective. Democracy cannot survive when whole communities are portrayed as dangerous, disposable, or undeserving. In a time when their blame and of the system's failure on so many people, Dr. King's voice will call the nation back to truth, to courage, and to moral imagination. He will remind us that America does not become great by building walls of fear, but by building bridges of justice.

[00:35:07] Ultimately, Dr. King would tell today's leader what he told the nations decades ago: We are now faced with the fact that tomorrow is today. We are confronted with the fierce urgency of now. The question remains whether we would choose fear or the hard holy work of building the beloved community. Mr. Speaker, Dr. King delivered his last public address on april the 3rd 1968 in memphis that day before he dot before he was shot his final words to the nation

[00:35:45] made clear his unshakable faith that whatever challenges we face we will achieve peace and justice in our future if we continue to strive for it he said these words and i want to remind us i've been to the mountaintop and i've looked over and i've seen the promised land and i may not get there with you But I want you to know tonight that we as a people will get to the promised land.

[00:36:13] Dr. King's words, his faith in humanity, and his hope for the future give us the direction today as we try to continue to build the beloved community. Mr. Speaker, I move today that as we adjourn, that we do this in memory and honor of the Reverend Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.

[00:36:36] Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:36:47] The Delegate from Enrico, Delegate McQuinn moves that when the House adjourned today, it do so in the honor and memory of the Reverend Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.

[00:37:10] All those in favor shall please rise. The motion is agreed to. The Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Tran. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:37:27] I ask that we move back to the first morning hour for the purpose of an introduction. Just throw water right on top of that, huh? Cold water. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, members of the House and the gallery today, we are joined by advocates with Virginia High School Democrats, and I ask that they please rise.

[00:37:44] Virginia High School Democrats was established in 1932 and is the oldest state chapter of High School Democrats in America. With over 700 members and 40 chapters across the Commonwealth, they're committed to fighting for the rights of all Virginians, as well as training and mobilizing the next generation of Democrats.

[00:38:03] These youth show us that, no matter your age, you are able to participate and help shape our democracy and advocate for the issues you believe in. Please join me in giving a warm house welcome to the Virginia High School Democrats. Welcome.

[00:38:27] Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Sewell. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, in the gallery today, we have the members of Kappa Alpha Psi Fraternity Incorporated. Please stand.

[00:38:42] Kappa Alpha Psi is a historically black fraternity founded on January 5, 1911 on the campus of Indiana University in Bloomington, Indiana. Today, the fraternity boasts membership of over 250,000 and has over 700 collegiate and alumni chapters located in the United States and abroad.

[00:39:02] Kappa Alpha Psi's motto is achievement in every field of human endeavor, and that is reflected in their programming. Dedicated to community service, social welfare, academic scholarship, civil rights, education, and membership, the members of Kappa Alpha Psi Fraternity Incorporated have active programs running in every corner of the Commonwealth.

[00:39:23] Today, they have gathered in Richmond for their 17th annual John T. Lanier Sr. Kappa Alpha Psi Virginia Legislative Day and 3rd annual A. Donald McEachin Luncheon. Mr. Speaker, I request that the members join me in extending a warm house welcome.

[00:39:47] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol. I guess y'all are rooting for Indiana tonight? I don't know. Trickle call the calendar. Members of the House, calendar for today, Monday, January 19th, 2026.

[00:40:05] Page 1 of the printed version, if you're following that way. First category, memorial resolutions laid on the speaker's table. The memorial resolutions will be adopted in block. In block are listed on pages 1 and 2 of today's calendar. Does any member desire to remove a resolution from the block? Hearing none, all those in favor of adopting in block, the memorial resolutions laid on speaker's table is listed on pages 1 and 2.

[00:40:28] of the calendar shall rise. The resolutions are agreed to. Continuing with today's calendar, next category, page two, commending resolutions laid on the speaker's table. The commending resolutions will be adopted in block, listed on pages two through four of today's calendar.

[00:40:51] Does any member desire to remove a resolution from the block? The delegate from Looneybury, Delegate Wright. Mr. Speaker, I'd like to remove two resolutions from the block. I remove, I move that H.J.R. 11 on page 4 on today's calendar be passed by until Wednesday, February the 4th.

[00:41:11] Without objection, H.J.R. 11 is passed by until Wednesday, February 4th. The Delegate from Looneyberg. Delegate. Mr. Speaker, I move that H.J.R. 13 on page 4 of today's calendar be passed by until Thursday, February the 5th.

[00:41:29] Without objection, H.J.R. 13 is passed by until Thursday, February 5th. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Are there any other? You're welcome. Are there any other resolutions that need to be removed from the block? Hearing none, all those in favor of adopting unblocked or commended resolutions laid on Speaker's table, as listed on pages 2 through 4 on the calendar, will say aye.

[00:41:48] All those opposed, nay. The resolutions are agreed to. Ms. Speaker, that completes today's calendar. Per House Rule 51, the House is returned to the morning hour. Does the Clerk have any additional announcements or communications? Remind the body that there is a joint assembly at 4 o'clock today.

[00:42:05] The Majority Leader will have more to say about that momentarily. Looking ahead to our committee meeting schedule, Mr. Speaker, the Committee on Finance is meeting one half hour, excuse me, 15 minutes upon adjournment in the House over in House Room B on the second floor of the GAB.

[00:42:24] Finance at 15 minutes upon adjournment. The Committee on Appropriations is not meeting tomorrow, but in lieu, excuse me, meeting later this afternoon. And in lieu of that time, several

subcommittees are not meeting. However, there is one meeting, which is the Appropriations Comp and Retirement Subcommittee.

[00:42:41] That'll be 30 minutes upon adjournment of the House up on the 12th floor Appropriations Committee Room. And then the Committee for Courts of Justice. They'll be meeting immediately upon adjournment of the House in the House Committee Room C on the second floor. So Finance, Courts, and one sub from Approps will be meeting.

[00:43:01] That's all the legislative activities for the afternoon. Then at 5 o'clock, the Northern Virginia delegation caucus is not meeting because of the aforementioned State of the Commonwealth stress, so that will be rescheduled or picked up next week, presumably. Looking ahead to tomorrow, Tuesday, January 20th, the Conservative caucus is meeting bright and early at 7.30 a.m.

[00:43:22] They will be in House Subcommittee Room 8, up on the 8th floor of the GAB. The Committee on Education's K-12 Subcommittee, they'll be meeting at 7.30 in the House Committee Room A in the lower level of the General Assembly Building.

[00:43:40] Also at 7.30, the Virginia Private College and University Caucus. They'll be meeting at 7.30 up on the 7th Floor South Meeting Room, which is on the schedule as well from which I am reading. Committee on Health and Human Services, Chairman Willett's committee now.

[00:43:58] We'll be meeting at 8.30, and that's in House Committee Room C on the second floor, so they'll be at 8.30. Then at 9, Committee on Transportation, we'll meet against Normal Time Tuesday, House Committee Room B on the second floor. Going back slightly, after HHS's committee is finished, then HHS Subcommittee on Health will meet immediately upon adjournment of the full committee in the same room, House Room C.

[00:44:23] The Democratic caucus will be meeting at 11.30 tomorrow in House Room 1, and the Republican caucus will be at 11.15, 11.30 as well. So both caucuses at 11.30 tomorrow, the Democrats in House Room 1, Republicans in House Room 2. Mr. Speaker, that is all the announcements I have, sir.

[00:44:40] The delegate from Arlington, Delegate Hope. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, just to clarify the clerk's reading of the schedule, the House Courts of Justice Committee will meet immediately following adjournment of the Finance Committee. Okay. I apologize. I didn't have that. I'll make sure we do that going forward.

[00:44:58] The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House stand in recess until 3.30 p.m., and may I speak to that motion? The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, members of this House. We ask everyone to be in your seats by 3.30 in the chamber because at 3.45 we will start receiving the Senate and everyone else here for the State of the Commonwealth.

[00:45:21] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves at the House standing recess until 3.30 p.m. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves at the House standing recess until 3.30 p.m. As many as favor the motion will say aye.

[00:45:38] Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands in recess until 3.30 p.m.



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